A Funny Film About Manhole Covers Wins a Big Prize

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A comedy about two people who steal manhole covers has won the top prize at the Tokyo International Film Festival.

The film is called "Sister Brother Manhole Cover." It tells the story of Viktor and Malina, a brother and sister who make money by stealing manhole covers and copper statues. Their adventure gets wild when a stolen **bronze** statue of a national hero falls on Viktor's foot.

The prize is worth 3 million yen, about $19,000. The festival's **jury** leader, Rolf de Heer, said the **jury** picked the film because it is both touching and playful, and shows humanity and compassion toward its characters.

The director, Milcho Manchevski, could not be in Tokyo, so the film's **producer** and its two stars accepted the prize. "We came here to Tokyo with a manhole cover, and we are going back to Macedonia with a beautiful award," said **producer** Jane Kortoshev.

Another prize, the Special **Jury** Prize, went to "Magic Atlas," an **animated** film from Singapore that its artist spent about ten years making.

Word Treasure

jury -- A small group of people chosen to judge a competition and pick the winners.

bronze -- A brownish metal made mostly of copper, often used for statues.

animated -- Made with drawings or computer images that move, rather than filmed with real actors.

producer -- A person who organizes and oversees the making of a film.

Background you need

At a film festival, judges called a jury choose the best films and give prizes.

This winning film is a comedy -- a funny story about a brother and sister.

It was made in North Macedonia, a small country in Europe.

Break it down

WHO: Director Milcho Manchevski and his film's producer and stars
WHAT: His comedy 'Sister Brother Manhole Cover' won the top prize
WHERE: At the Tokyo International Film Festival
WHY: The jury loved that the film is touching and playful and kind to its characters

Why it matters

It proves a small, funny film from a faraway country can beat big productions -- a good reminder that your own silly ideas can go far.

Test what you remember

1. What is the winning film about?

(A) A tennis match
(B) A space trip
(C) A bank robbery
(D) A brother and sister who steal manhole covers

2. Where did the film win its prize?

(A) Paris
(B) New York
(C) Tokyo
(D) London

3. How much is the prize worth?

(A) About $19,000
(B) One dollar
(C) Nothing at all
(D) $1 million

4. Who said the film is touching and playful?

(A) Jury leader Rolf de Heer
(B) A fan
(C) The director's mother
(D) The mayor

5. Why couldn't the director accept the prize himself?

(A) He was not in Tokyo
(B) He was asleep
(C) He lost the film
(D) He was busy filming a match

6. What is 'Magic Atlas'?

(A) A map book
(B) A video game
(C) An animated film from Singapore that also won a prize
(D) A tennis racket

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: A 4: A 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Producer Jane Kortoshev: Joked that they came to Tokyo with a manhole cover and are going back with a beautiful award.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):